

Intergenerational Trauma and Psychological Repression in Survivors

Introduction

The Jeju 4.3 Incident stands as one of the most traumatic and long-silenced events in modern Korean history. Beginning on April 3, 1948, and continuing in waves of violence until 1954, the incident resulted in the deaths of an estimated 25,000 to 30,000 people—approximately 10% of Jeju Island's population at the time. What makes this event particularly significant is not only the scale of violence but the enduring psychological consequences that extended far beyond the immediate victims. Survivors were not merely left to cope with grief; they were forced into silence by a political climate that suppressed memory itself. As a result, the Jeju 4.3 Incident offers a powerful case study of how trauma can be both internalized (psychological repression) and transmitted across generations (intergenerational trauma).

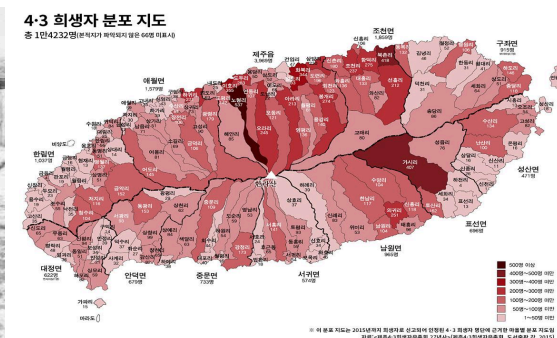
Historical Context

To understand the psychological aftermath, it is necessary to first examine the historical conditions that produced it. Following Korea's liberation from Japanese colonial rule in 1945, ideological tensions between left-wing and right-wing groups intensified under the influence of Cold War geopolitics. On Jeju Island, resistance against the planned separate elections in the South—viewed by many as cementing division—sparked protests that escalated into armed conflict. The South Korean government, supported by U.S. military authorities, responded with severe counterinsurgency measures. Entire villages were burned, and civilians were indiscriminately labeled as communist sympathizers.

What followed was not only mass violence but systematic erasure. For decades, the South Korean state framed the incident as a communist rebellion, effectively criminalizing survivors and the bereaved. Public discussion was suppressed, and even mentioning the incident could lead to suspicion or punishment. This prolonged silence created the conditions for psychological repression, where individuals suppress traumatic memories not by choice, but as a survival mechanism within an oppressive social structure.



Photo of Jeju 4.3 Incident



Distribution of deaths during Jeju 4.3 Incident

Psychological Repression in Survivors

Psychological repression, as understood in trauma theory, refers to the unconscious exclusion of distressing memories from conscious awareness. In the context of Jeju 4.3, repression functioned both individually and collectively. Survivors often avoided speaking about their experiences, even within their own families. This was not simply denial—it was a form of protection. Speaking out could result in social ostracization, loss of employment, or even state surveillance.

However, repression does not eliminate trauma; it merely buries it. Many survivors exhibited symptoms now associated with post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), including nightmares, hypervigilance, and emotional numbing. Yet, due to the stigma surrounding the event and the lack of psychological support at the time, these symptoms remained largely unacknowledged.

One of the most striking aspects of this repression is its normalization. Silence became embedded in daily life, shaping communication patterns and emotional expression. Parents avoided discussing the past with their children, creating a generational gap not only in knowledge but in emotional understanding. The absence of narrative became a defining feature of the trauma itself.

Intergenerational Trauma

Despite this silence, the trauma of Jeju 4.3 did not end with the survivors. It was transmitted—subtly yet powerfully—to subsequent generations. This phenomenon, known as intergenerational trauma, occurs when the psychological effects of a traumatic event are passed down to children and even grandchildren.

In Jeju, this transmission often occurred through indirect means: emotional atmospheres, behavioral patterns, and fragmented stories. Children grew up sensing fear, anxiety, or unresolved grief in their parents, even if the cause was never explicitly explained. This aligns with psychological research suggesting that trauma can be communicated through nonverbal cues, such as tone, silence, and emotional withdrawal.

Moreover, the social stigma attached to the incident reinforced this transmission. Families associated with victims were sometimes labeled as “red” (communist), affecting their social and economic opportunities. This created a persistent sense of insecurity and marginalization that extended beyond the original event. In this way, trauma became not only psychological but also structural, embedded in social identity and collective memory.

Interestingly, the second and third generations often experienced a form of “postmemory”—a term coined by scholar Marianne Hirsch to describe the relationship that later generations have with the traumatic experiences of their predecessors. These individuals inherit memories they did not directly experience, yet feel deeply connected to them. In Jeju, many

descendants have reported a strong emotional response upon learning about the incident later in life, often accompanied by a sense of anger, grief, or a desire for justice.

Aftermath of the survivors

The late 20th and early 21st centuries marked a turning point in the public acknowledgment of the Jeju 4.3 Incident. Democratization in South Korea created space for historical re-evaluation. In 2000, the government passed the Special Act on the Jeju 4.3 Incident, leading to an official investigation and the establishment of the Jeju 4.3 Peace Foundation. In 2003, President Roh Moo-hyun issued a formal apology on behalf of the state.

These efforts represented more than political gestures; they were crucial steps toward psychological healing. Acknowledgment validates the experiences of survivors, allowing them to integrate their memories into a coherent narrative rather than suppressing them. Memorials, such as the Jeju 4.3 Peace Park, provide physical spaces where memory can be collectively processed.

However, healing is neither immediate nor complete. For many survivors, decades of repression have left deep psychological scars. Some have only begun to speak about their experiences late in life, often expressing regret for the years of silence. For younger generations, the challenge lies in reconciling inherited trauma with contemporary identity—understanding the past without being defined by it.

Personal Reflection

What makes the Jeju 4.3 Incident particularly compelling is not just its historical significance, but its emotional resonance in the present. Growing up in Korea—or even learning about this event from afar—one cannot ignore the profound silence that once surrounded it. This silence is not empty; it is filled with suppressed voices, fragmented memories, and unspoken grief.

Reflecting on this, one realizes that trauma is not only about what is remembered, but also about what is forgotten—or forced to be forgotten. The absence of stories can be as powerful as their presence. In many ways, the intergenerational impact of Jeju 4.3 challenges the assumption that time alone heals wounds. Without acknowledgment and dialogue, trauma can persist in invisible yet pervasive ways.

At the same time, there is a sense of cautious hope. The increasing openness surrounding the incident suggests a shift from repression to recognition. Younger generations are engaging with the past through education, art, and public discourse. This does not erase the trauma, but it transforms it—from a source of silent suffering into a catalyst for understanding and empathy.

Conclusion

The Jeju 4.3 Incident illustrates how trauma operates across both time and silence. Survivors, constrained by political repression, internalized their suffering, leading to long-term psychological consequences. Yet, this trauma did not remain confined to one

generation; it was transmitted through emotional, social, and cultural channels to their descendants.

Understanding this process is essential not only for historical accuracy but for ethical responsibility. Recognizing intergenerational trauma allows societies to address the lingering effects of past violence, moving beyond denial toward meaningful reconciliation. In the case of Jeju, the gradual breaking of silence represents a critical step in this process.

Ultimately, the legacy of Jeju 4.3 is not only one of tragedy, but also of resilience. It reminds us that while trauma can be inherited, so too can the capacity for healing—provided that memory is acknowledged, voices are heard, and silence is no longer enforced.

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